

Writing Seminar: Syllabus

Overview

Your Writing Seminars are affiliated with your Humanities Core Sequence, and they are structured to help you succeed as a writer in your core courses. These seminars also constitute their own course, however, which is pass/fail and necessary to graduate. Throughout the quarter, we will use your written work for Human Being and Citizen as a point of departure for thinking through best practices in argumentative writing. While I have set topics for discussion corresponding to each week, it is best to think of these topics as provocative, rather than delimiting: it is most important to me that you become a better writer. The tools and approaches I prepare are means toward that end.

Expectations

Writing seminars require attentive and intentional engagement with the ideas and expressions of your peers. For each of our three meetings, you must:

- Prepare
- Attend
- Engage

Preparedness

Each seminar, you will have a short assignment due at least one day before we meet, often in three parts. In general, for the first part you will review an informational sheet or video of my creation; for the second part, you will produce some written work of your own; and for the third part, you will engage with the work of your peers. You must complete all three parts in order to be prepared for seminar.

Attendance

You are required to attend each of the three (3) writing seminars on your schedule this quarter.

Engagement

Of course, while present in writing seminar, you are expected to contribute productively to conversation. Learning is a thing we do together – no one learns alone! – and this is especially true of learning about writing. Practice makes competent.

Accessibility

The University of Chicago is committed to ensuring equitable access to our academic programs and services. Students with disabilities who have been approved for the use of academic accommodations by Student Disability Services (SDS) and need a reasonable accommodation(s) to participate fully in this course should follow the procedures established by SDS for using accommodations. Timely notifications are required in order to ensure that your accommodations can be implemented. Please meet with me to discuss your access needs in this class after you have completed the SDS procedures for requesting accommodations. To contact SDS: website: disabilities.uchicago.edu phone: (773) 702-6000 email: disabilities@uchicago.edu

Absence-Failure

This is a pass/fail course. If, for any of our seminar meetings, you have not prepared in full, are physically absent, or are unable to engage while physically present, I will count you absent from that seminar meeting. If you are absent for any single writing seminar, you will need to take steps to make up your absence as determined by your instructor. I will consider an absence from two or more seminars grounds for failure in this course.

Individual Feedback

I am available for individual consultation by appointment throughout the quarter, either in-person (in Harper or my office) or virtually (via Zoom). I am happy to discuss with you any aspect of the writing process, from hunch to product. If you are looking to receive individualized writing advice on a specific assignment, however, you must fill out the cover sheet, in its entirety, to be found here:

<https://forms.gle/rkh9suBV7nkwbmh56>

I will not respond to requests for feedback made within 24 hours of an assignment being due. On account of the sheer volume of students I work with, if you contact me fewer than 48 hours before your assignment is due, I may not be able to respond quickly enough to be of help.

Schedule

Each week will have an assignment, usually in two parts (produce; engage). Please look to the informational sheet for the each week for details about individual assignments.

Week 4

Diagnosing Argument: Claims, Grounds, and Warrants

Week 5

Arranging Argument: Effective Paragraphs

Week 10

Arranging Argument: Effective Essays